

Code white

Code White is the alert initiated to manage patients, visitors or members of the public who exhibit abusive, aggressive, or violent behavior, which is directed at patients, hospital staff or hospital property. It may also be used to summon the immediate presence of the administration and security staff when warranted.

The areas of the Hospital covered by the Code White Emergency Aggressive Response policy include the adult, pediatric and maternity emergency departments, critical care areas, wards, outpatient department, laboratories, radiology, procedure suites, hospital administration, and any other department in the hospital building.

Prior to initiating Code White, the senior most staff present on site should:

- Find out why the abusive or aggressive person is upset or angry.
- Be non-confrontational.
- Try to diffuse the situation by employing interpersonal and communication skills; if necessary, seek the assistance of someone else who could communicate more effectively; request assistance from other senior staff if required.

If the person does not leave, continues to be abusive, there is threat of violence, or if a situation is likely to escalate beyond control, the senior most staff present at the site of the incident may directly, or by seeking the assistance of a subordinate, initiate Code White (911).

Code White may also be activated if:

- A suspicious person is found loitering around;
- A person under the obvious influence of alcohol or drugs refuses to leave immediately when told;
- An outsider is found trying to impersonate a doctor or any other staff;
- A person is trying to abduct a baby or child;
- A person is found stalking or attempting to molest a lady;

- A theft is being committed.

To activate Code White, dial 9111 and follow the next steps:

- 1. When you call 9111, a message will appear to press 1, to confirm that you want to report a violence case.**
- 2. Once activated, the staff sends a voice message that includes the following:**
 - Exact location of incident
 - Nature of incident
 - Your name and designation.
- 3. End the call. The message will reach to the code white team and will respond promptly. Code white team consists of the following members:**
 - Security in-charge (5144)
 - PSO (5021)
 - Duty Nursing Officer (5009)

ER Psychiatric patients:

In the case of incidents involving patients with acute psychiatric conditions causing abusive or violent behavior, the clinician may further phone the on-call psychiatrist at Masarra Hospital for advice on how to deal with, and perhaps even sedate the patient.

Admitted patients:

The admitted clients are referred to the psychiatric department at the hospital level for consultation.

Restraining Patients:

If the patient is aggressive and uncontrolled, the staff shall restrain the patient via executing restrain policy available in the document management system.

Staff on duty at Royal Hospital, when paged as above, shall immediately proceed to the scene. While on the way, the Security in-charge shall instruct 1-2 other security guards on duty to also report at that location.

The Code White team, under the leadership of the Duty Director or Patient Services Officer, shall take stock of the situation, reassure the staff involved, and do what is

necessary to bring the situation under control. The aggressive person shall be treated with respect and professionalism to the degree expected in that situation.

The Patient Service Officer will notify the Police in the following situations:

- Whenever there is a real or perceived threat that lives are in danger;
- When the Code White team determines the situation is beyond their abilities;
- Whenever an edged weapon or firearm is involved;
- When the aggressive behavior occurs beyond the limits of decency;
- When the aggressor is not a client and threatens staff and client safety;
- When theft is involved.

In such an eventuality, the Security shall detain the person till arrival of the Police. However, the offender shall not be physically restrained unless a staff is being assaulted.

In the case of theft, till the Police arrive and take action, the Security shall prevent entry to the incident location/s and ensure that nothing is touched or moved.

The Patient Services Officer is officially responsible for liaison with the Police. Staff involved in the incident shall make their statements to the Police only in the presence of the Patient Services Officer.

Once the Code White situation has been dealt with, the senior most staff involved in the incident, staff witness or the in-charge at the location where the incident occurred, shall report an incident in the incident reporting and learning system (IRLS). In case there is a delay or more than 5 minutes in the members of the Code White team arriving on the scene, this should be mentioned in the incident report. Workplace violence events are immediately forwarded by the Quality and Patient safety Department to the concerned parties for feedback. Further, workplace violence quarterly reports are shared with the concerned directors for feedback and monitoring.

As a follow up to the incident report, the department director and nursing officer shall hold a debriefing meeting on the next working day (inclusive of the person who activated the Code White and the staff who responded to the alert), enter his remarks and action taken, and any lessons learnt to avoid or handle better such situations in future in the Incident reporting and learning system.

Considering the location of most Code White incidents in hospitals, the Emergency Department staff are specially advised to:

- Be vigilant about strangers entering unauthorized areas;
- Identify those patients/attendants who are known to be violent;
- Be alert to recognize precursors of violence and assess the situation;
- Attempt to defuse the situation or call Security if concerned;
- Discourage loiterers by establishing whether or not they are attending as patients, and request that they leave if they have no reason to be present;
- Adhere to existing simple security precautions, e.g., lock doors, restrict visitors, limit attendants, notify Security if crowd control is warranted.

In dealing with Code White situations, the staff present at the scene should remember to:

- Remain calm, cautious and courteous; be assertive, not aggressive; avoid creating panic;
- Converse and answer questions courteously; do only what is told, nothing more;
- In the case of violence, particularly if multiple offenders are involved, staff of the adjacent areas should lock doors and stay out of the danger area;
- Take particular note of the appearance, clothing, age and identifying marks of the aggressor;
- If assailant flees, make a note of routes taken, vehicle details and any other pertinent information;
- Ensure the phone line in that location is kept open.